

"No state is free from attempts to subvert public examinations by vested interests. The new anti-leak and -cheating law is more focused and will ensure stringent punishment for the guilty"

part of the system earlier. It may be related to only a few students, but it created confusion. And in one or two places, some isolated incidents took place. In those places, the local police took preventive measures. Everything is there in black and white and it will be presented in court. I am nobody to give a certificate. I am responsible for giving solutions. The prime minister is 100 per cent committed to make the country into an economic superpower. When it comes to entrance tests, there is no shortcut, we need to make things hundred per cent foolproof. That we will do. Looking into that, we have formed a very high-profile, high-level reform committee. We are very clear in our intentions.

"In 2014, there were around 51,000 medical seats. Today we have 110,000 seats. We have doubled seats, created a transparent test system. This is our commitment to medical education"

Q. You have just notified the rules for the law to take penal action against those attempting to cheat and subvert examination systems. What's behind this and what kind of impact will it have in cleansing the system?
No state, whichever party may be in power there, is free of this affliction. I have data to prove it. Unfair practices, cheating, tampering of public examinations, gangsters, lobbies, those with vested interests are involved in this. For the first time, we have brought in laws to prevent this. There were laws, but we have made it focused, to ensure that those tampering with public examinations will receive stringent punishment. Be it under the old system or the new system, no one will be spared.

Q. Some people who have been arrested recently in NEET, will they be tried under the new law?
Maybe. But I assure you stringent action will be there.

Q. When it comes to recruitment examinations too, we have seen leakages of question papers, postponements and other such issues. Will the committee that is formed to look into the NTA also go into the recruitment exams?
Whoever disrupts public examinations, either for jobs or for admission into educational institutes, will face action. In both cases, what's tampered with is the test. The committee that is there to relook at the structure and functioning of the NTA will certainly look into it, as the NTA, though it is primarily for education entrance tests, is also conducting tests for recruitments.

Q. Many of the tests are conducted by the state agencies. How do you want to take them along?
Every state faces this challenge...this cancer. Every government department faces it, as all departments carry out recruitment. We all want it to be tamper-proof and 100 per cent error-free. So, both states and the Union government will have to deal with this challenge together. We are committed to that.

Q. You've resumed charge as the Union minister for education. Besides dealing with the immediate crisis, what will be your key areas of focus for the education ministry?
Education is the mothership department. India is destined to become an economic superpower. The ball is not just rolling, it's unstoppable. In the next 25 years, India has to be a developed country. The 21st century is the era of knowledge-based economy. India has its own strength in this area. Our education ministry's focus is on how to fulfil both domestic needs and global aspirations. We have to create more entrepreneurs. We have to create more job-ready students, more professionals with more skills. The National Education Policy (NEP) has recommended everything in its document and the successful implementation of the NEP is our priority. ■